

New York Primary Upends Democratic Establishment: Three Socialist-Backed Candidates Win

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Less than seven months into his term, New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani took a risky political bet and won big. All three congressional candidates he **endorsed** in Tuesday's Democratic primaries emerged victorious, including two who **toppled** sitting lawmakers. The results sent shockwaves through the party and highlighted deepening divides over Israel, economic policy, and generational change. The night's biggest upset came in the 13th District, where 32-year-old organizer Darializa Avila Chevalier narrowly defeated five-term Rep. Adriano Espaillat, 71, the chair of the Congressional Hispanic Caucus. In the 10th District, progressive Brad Lander decisively unseated two-term Rep. Dan Goldman. And in the open 7th District, Assemblymember Claire Valdez beat Antonio Reynoso, who had the backing of retiring Rep. Nydia Velázquez. All three winners are **democratic socialists** who campaigned on ambitious platforms: **universal healthcare**, higher taxes on the rich, and sharp criticism of Israel. "These victories prove that **democratic socialists** are building a winning **coalition**," said Grace Mausser, co-chair of the NYC chapter of the **Democratic Socialists** of America. The DSA has seen a surge in membership since Mamdani's own upset mayoral win last year, and similar candidates have recently won in Washington, D.C., and advanced in Los Angeles. But the embrace of democratic socialism gives Republicans **ammunition**. The National Republican Congressional Committee quickly declared that the Democratic Party "officially belongs to the socialists," warning voters to be "terrified." It remains unclear whether this urban blueprint can translate to suburban or rural districts. Yet for now, the message from New York is clear: a growing number of Democratic voters, especially young ones, are demanding bolder, more confrontational leadership and they're willing to shake up the establishment to get it.

Word Treasure

endorsed -- Publicly declared support for a candidate, hoping others will vote for them.

toppled -- Caused to fall from power, here defeated in an election.

ammunition -- Material used metaphorically to attack or discredit opponents.

coalition -- An alliance of different groups working together toward a common goal.

democratic socialists -- Members of a political movement that advocates for socialist policies like universal healthcare within a democratic system.

universal healthcare -- A system where every citizen has access to medical services, usually paid for by taxes.

Background you need

The New York Democratic primaries are often seen as a bellwether for the party's direction, as the city has a large number of progressive activists.

Zohran Mamdani, a former state assemblymember and democratic socialist, unexpectedly won the mayoralty in 2025, signaling a shift in the city's politics.

Adriano Espaillat, who lost this primary, was the first Dominican-born member of Congress and chaired the Congressional Hispanic Caucus (a group that advocates for Hispanic issues in Washington).

The Democratic Socialists of America (DSA) saw a surge in membership after Bernie Sanders's 2016 presidential campaign and has helped elect officials like Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez in 2018.

Republicans have long used the term 'socialist' as a negative label; this primary gives them a fresh talking point to paint the entire Democratic Party as extreme.

Break it down

LEAD: Mayor Zohran Mamdani's endorsements win big, sending shockwaves through the party.

+ detail: All three candidates he backed won; two unseated incumbents.

UPSETS: Highlights of key races.

+ 13th District: Avila Chevalier defeats Espaillat (5-term, Hispanic Caucus chair).

+ 10th District: Lander defeats Goldman.

+ 7th District: Valdez wins open seat against Reynoso.

PLATFORM: Winners are democratic socialists campaigning on universal healthcare, higher taxes, and sharp criticism of Israel.

REACTION: DSA declares a 'winning coalition' while NRCC says Democrats 'officially belong to the socialists.'

CONTEXT: DSA surge since Mamdani's win, with similar victories in D.C. and Los Angeles.

UNRESOLVED: Can this urban progressive blueprint translate to suburban or rural districts?

Why it matters

This primary reveals a deepening generational and ideological rift within the Democratic Party, with young voters pushing for more radical policies. The outcome could influence national politics and shape debates on economic inequality and foreign policy for years.

Test what you remember

1. Who is the current mayor of New York mentioned in the article?
 - (A) Adriano Espaillat
 - (B) Brad Lander
 - (C) Zohran Mamdani
 - (D) Dan Goldman
2. How many congressional candidates endorsed by Mayor Mamdani won their primaries?
 - (A) 1
 - (B) 2
 - (C) 3
 - (D) 4
3. Which long-serving congressman was defeated in the 13th District?
 - (A) Dan Goldman
 - (B) Brad Lander
 - (C) Adriano Espaillat
 - (D) Antonio Reynoso
4. What is one key policy that all three winning candidates campaigned on?
 - (A) Lower taxes for the wealthy
 - (B) Universal healthcare
 - (C) Privatizing public schools
 - (D) Reducing military spending
5. What did the National Republican Congressional Committee say after the primaries?
 - (A) They congratulated the winners
 - (B) They warned that the Democratic Party now belongs to socialists
 - (C) They announced their own socialist candidates
 - (D) They declared the results invalid
6. What uncertainty does the article raise about these democratic socialist victories?
 - (A) Whether the candidates can raise enough money
 - (B) Whether the candidates will switch parties
 - (C) Whether this urban blueprint can work in suburban or rural districts
 - (D) Whether the mayor will resign

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Progressive momentum:** Activists see these wins as a mandate for bold change, proving that democratic socialist ideas like universal healthcare can win elections and energize new, young voters who were previously disillusioned.
- 2. Electoral risk:** Critics argue the party is moving too far left, alienating moderate and suburban voters. The socialist label gives Republicans a powerful weapon to scare swing voters, potentially harming Democrats in competitive general elections.
- 3. Political realignment:** These victories are part of a broader shift where class-based issues and younger demographics are reshaping party priorities. The old guard's defeat suggests an anti-establishment mood that transcends individual races.
- 4. A blueprint or a bubble?:** If these candidates succeed in office, they could build a model for national expansion. However, if they fail to deliver on promises or lose in purple districts, the movement might fizzle or provoke a centrist backlash.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):